

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Satavahanas & the Deccan - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The Satavahanas & the Deccan	
01 SCOPE AND GOVERNING THEMES: A DECCAN NETWORK POLITY MacroPTQ can open with the network polity theme and prove it.	02 DECCAN GEOGRAPHY, ROUTES AND RESOURCES The Deccan plateau is not a solid block.
03 POST-MAURYAN CONTEXT: LOCALITIES BEFORE CONSOLIDATION Local and regional sites (major local sites and major sites).	04 SOURCE MATRIX: PURANAS, INSCRIPTIONS, COINS, ARCHAEOLOGY AND TEXTS (Literature, coins, inscriptions, Puranas, inscriptions, coins, archaeology).
05 CHRONOLOGY AND GENEALOGY DEBATES Chronology, chronology and genealogy debates is avoided by.	06 SHUKA, KANHA AND THE PROBLEM OF DYNASTIC BEGINNINGS The Puranas and the dynastic myths, whereas Satavahana beginnings.
07 SATAKARNI I, NAGARJUNA AND NANEHGAT Nagarjuna is important for both genealogy and women's authority.	08 POLITICAL GEOGRAPHY AND CAPITALS: A SHIFTING MULTI-CENTRED REALM Real political geography and capital administration are not identical.
09 ADMINISTRATION: AMARAS, OFFICERS AND PRACTICAL REACH Amara and officers show governance capacity. They do not prove it.	10 LOCAL ELITES, FEUDATORIES AND UNEVEN SOVEREIGNTY Microsites, microsites and other local ruling families were not.
11 WESTERN KSHATRAPAS: CONFLICT, PORTS, PASSES AND REGIONAL POWER MacroPTQ can trace the conflict through geography, evidence and.	12 GAUTAMIPUTRA SATAKARNI, GAUTAMI BALASHUKA AND KOTAL IDEOLOGY Gautami is the best documented Satavahana ruler because his.
13 NAHAPANA OVERSTRIKES: HOW TO READ THE COIN EVIDENCE INSTRUMENT: PROPOSED: Use the coin as evidence, significance and links.	14 YASTHUPUTRA PULUMAYI, RUDRADAMAN AND NEGOTIATED RIVALRY Pulumay is not merely a weak successor. He cannot record it.
15 YAJNA SRI SATAKARNI, LATER RULERS AND DECLINE High in SE toward the western struggle and a counterweight to the east.	16 AGRARIAN BASE: IRON, PADDY, COTTON AND WATER Iron tools, paddy transplantation, cotton, wadis, rivers and river delta.
17 LAND GRANTS AND FISCAL IMMUNITIES: AN EARLY INSTITUTIONAL TEMPLATE Early grants are fewer and less standardized than later Gupta and.	18 CRAFTS, GUILDS AND TOWNS Early Harappan Deccan towns were production and exchange nodes, not.
19 INLAND AND COASTAL TRADE: PORTS, PASSES AND MARKET TOWNS MacroPTQ can trace the coastal trade through geography, evidence and.	20 ROMAN AND MEDITERRANEAN CONTACT: EVIDENCE WITHOUT DIPLOMATIC CLAIMS MacroPTQ can show who controls, localisation and regional effect.
21 COINAGE: METALS, SYMBOLS, PORTRAITS AND POLITICAL USE MacroPTQ can trace the coinage in the famous inscriptions.	22 SOCIETY: VARNA IDEOLOGY, PRACTICE AND MOBILITY Brahmanism is a process, not an instant conception of.
23 MATRIMONY, ROYAL WOMEN AND DONOR AGENCY MacroPTQ is not the same as marriage.	24 OCCUPATIONAL GROUPS, MERCHANTS AND SOCIAL MOBILITY MacroPTQ can show evidence to discuss mobility, but note the.
25 RELIGION AND PLURAL PATRONAGE Patronage does not automatically mean private belief or the religion.	26 PRAKRITI, BRAHMI, INSCRIPTIONS AND GATHA SATTASAI Early support and Gatha Sattasai are not identical.
27 WESTERN DECCAN CAVES: NASHIK, KARLA AND JUNA MacroPTQ can trace the Deccan caves from the Deccan caves.	28 AMARAVATI AND THE ANDHRA BUDDHIST LANDSCAPE MacroPTQ can trace the Deccan caves from the Deccan caves.
29 DECCAN SCHOOLS AND CULTURAL INTERACTION: BOUNDED SYNTHESIS MacroPTQ can trace the Deccan caves from the Deccan caves.	30 BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE All and Ministry of Culture heritage gateways were reflected on 29.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

The Satavahanas & the Deccan - Complete Topic Package 5

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 5

Hard MCQ 01	5
Hard MCQ 02	5
Hard MCQ 03	5
Hard MCQ 04	6
Hard MCQ 05	6
Hard MCQ 06	6
Hard MCQ 07	6
Hard MCQ 08	7
Hard MCQ 09	7
Hard MCQ 10	7
Hard MCQ 11	7
Hard MCQ 12	8
Hard MCQ 13	8
Hard MCQ 14	8
Hard MCQ 15	8
Hard MCQ 16	9
Hard MCQ 17	9
Hard MCQ 18	9
Hard MCQ 19	9
Hard MCQ 20	10
Hard MCQ 21	10
Hard MCQ 22	10
Hard MCQ 23	10
Hard MCQ 24	11
Hard MCQ 25	11
Hard MCQ 26	11
Hard MCQ 27	11

Hard MCQ 28	12
Hard MCQ 29	12
Hard MCQ 30	12
Hard MCQ 31	12
Hard MCQ 32	13
Hard MCQ 33	13
Hard MCQ 34	13
Hard MCQ 35	13
Hard MCQ 36	14
Hard MCQ 37	14
Hard MCQ 38	14
Hard MCQ 39	14
Hard MCQ 40	15
Hard MCQ 41	15
Hard MCQ 42	15
Hard MCQ 43	15
Hard MCQ 44	16
Hard MCQ 45	16
Hard MCQ 46	16
Hard MCQ 47	16
Hard MCQ 48	17
Remedial MCQ 49	17
Remedial MCQ 50	17
Remedial MCQ 51	17
Remedial MCQ 52	18
Remedial MCQ 53	18
Remedial MCQ 54	18
Remedial MCQ 55	18
Remedial MCQ 56	19
Remedial MCQ 57	19
Remedial MCQ 58	19
Remedial MCQ 59	19

Remedial MCQ 60	20
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	20
PYQ 01 - 2026 Prelims GS-I Q13: Amaravati Stupa	20
PYQ 02 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q41: Dhanyakataka	20
PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains Q1: rock-cut architecture	21
PYQ 04 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q42: stupa origin and function	21
Mains 10M-1 - Network polity	22
Mains 10M-2 - Nahapana overstrikes	22
Mains 10M-3 - Matronymics and women	23
Mains 15M-1 - Chronology, genealogy and political geography	23
Mains 15M-2 - Agrarian economy, grants and urban growth	24
Mains 15M-3 - Plural patronage	24
Mains 20M-1 - Deccan bridge	25
Mains 20M-2 - Centralization debate	25
Mains 20M-3 - Source criticism	26

The Satavahanas & the Deccan - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01

Question: Which description best captures the Satavahana polity?

- A. A layered Deccan kingdom working through officials, local chiefs and institutional networks.
- B. A uniformly centralized bureaucracy across the peninsula.
- C. A purely coastal thalassocracy.
- D. A stateless merchant federation.

Answer: A - A layered Deccan kingdom working through officials, local chiefs and institutional networks.

Explanation: Aharas and officers existed, but maharathis, mahabhojas and local families show uneven and negotiated sovereignty.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 02

Question: Which source combination is most appropriate for Satavahana chronology?

- A. Only Roman geographical texts.
- B. Puranic lists, inscriptions, coins and archaeology read together.
- C. Only Puranic lists.
- D. Only the Gatha Sattasai.

Answer: B - Puranic lists, inscriptions, coins and archaeology read together.

Explanation: No single source supplies a continuous and uncontested chronology.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 03

Question: What is the safest identification of Simuka?

- A. The author of the Junagadh inscription.
- B. The Kshatrapa defeated by Gautamiputra.
- C. The conventional founder in the dynastic sequence, with disputed absolute date and core.
- D. The last Satavahana ruler.

Answer: C - The conventional founder in the dynastic sequence, with disputed absolute date and core.

Explanation: Simuka heads the usual sequence, but the start date and original locus remain debated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 04

Question: Why is Naneghat politically important?

- A. It was the principal Ikshvaku capital.
- B. It contains Ashoka's major rock edicts.
- C. It was a Roman colony.
- D. It joined a strategic pass with royal portraits, genealogy and Brahmanical ritual claims.

Answer: D - It joined a strategic pass with royal portraits, genealogy and Brahmanical ritual claims.

Explanation: The pass made genealogy and ritual visible on a coast-plateau corridor.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 05

Question: Which statement about Naganika is correct?

- A. She is associated with the Naneghat record and major royal ritual claims.
- B. She composed the Junagadh Sanskrit prashasti.
- C. She was Nahapana's daughter.
- D. She founded the Ikshvaku dynasty.

Answer: A - She is associated with the Naneghat record and major royal ritual claims.

Explanation: Naganika/Nayanika demonstrates royal women's authority without proving female succession.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 06

Question: The term ahara in Satavahana records refers most safely to:

- A. A Vedic sacrifice.
- B. A large administrative division or district.
- C. A Buddhist relic mound.
- D. A coin-minting guild.

Answer: B - A large administrative division or district.

Explanation: Ahara is administrative vocabulary but does not prove Mauryan-level centralization.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 07

Question: What do maharathis and mahabhojas demonstrate?

- A. A standardized imperial civil service.
- B. Roman control of Deccan ports.
- C. The continuing importance of local ruling elites within Satavahana networks.
- D. The disappearance of local authority.

Answer: C - The continuing importance of local ruling elites within Satavahana networks.

Explanation: Their donations, coins and marriage ties show incorporation rather than replacement.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 08

Question: Which pairing is correct?

- A. Gautamiputra - Ikshvaku.
- B. Rudradaman - Satavahana.
- C. Pulumavi - Kushana.
- D. Nahapana - Kshaharata Kshatrapa.

Answer: D - Nahapana - Kshaharata Kshatrapa.

Explanation: Nahapana belonged to the Kshaharata line; Rudradaman was Kardamaka.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 09

Question: The main strategic issue in Satavahana-Kshatrapa conflict was:

- A. Changing control of western Deccan routes, Konkan access and ports.
- B. Conquest of Bactria.
- C. Control of the Kaveri delta alone.
- D. Possession of Pataliputra throughout the period.

Answer: A - Changing control of western Deccan routes, Konkan access and ports.

Explanation: Ports and passes made the western frontier economically and politically valuable.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 10

Question: Why are Gautamiputra's Nahapana overstrikes important?

- A. They show the dynasty issued no other metal.
- B. They materially corroborate political defeat and appropriation of usable silver stock.
- C. They prove all Indian trade used silver.
- D. They date every Satavahana ruler precisely.

Answer: B - They materially corroborate political defeat and appropriation of usable silver stock.

Explanation: Overstrikes are powerful event evidence but not complete frontier maps.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 11

Question: Who composed the best-known posthumous eulogy of Gautamiputra?

- A. Ushavadata.
- B. Queen Naganika.
- C. His mother Gautami Balashri.
- D. Rudradaman.

Answer: C - His mother Gautami Balashri.

Explanation: The Nashik prashasti is a maternal dynastic eulogy engraved during Pulumavi's reign.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 12

Question: Gautamiputra's claim to prevent varna mixture should be read as:

- A. Evidence that merchants disappeared.
- B. A Buddhist monastic rule.
- C. Proof of complete endogamy.
- D. Royal Brahmanical ideology rather than a demographic census.

Answer: D - Royal Brahmanical ideology rather than a demographic census.

Explanation: Prashasti language articulates desired order and political legitimacy.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 13

Question: Which statement on Vasisthiputra Pulumavi is safest?

- A. His coins in Andhra indicate a strong eastern Deccan phase.
- B. He permanently destroyed all Kshatrapas.
- C. He was the founder Simuka's brother.
- D. He wrote the Periplus.

Answer: A - His coins in Andhra indicate a strong eastern Deccan phase.

Explanation: Coin finds support eastern presence while western conflict continued.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 14

Question: Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription is useful because it:

- A. Is a neutral Satavahana tax register.
- B. Provides a rival prashasti claiming victories over a Satakarni and western territorial power.
- C. Proves no matrimonial ties existed.
- D. Was written in Tamil-Brahmi.

Answer: B - Provides a rival prashasti claiming victories over a Satakarni and western territorial power.

Explanation: Rival royal evidence checks unilateral dynastic narratives.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 15

Question: Yajna Sri Satakarni's ship coins most safely indicate:

- A. Roman political control.
- B. A documented oceanic empire.
- C. Maritime symbolism and commercial orientation.
- D. The absence of inland trade.

Answer: C - Maritime symbolism and commercial orientation.

Explanation: A ship motif is meaningful but cannot measure fleet size or monopoly.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 16

Question: What best describes Satavahana decline?

- A. An instant collapse caused only by Rome.
- B. A peaceful merger into the Kushana Empire.
- C. A single invasion that erased Deccan towns.
- D. Regional fragmentation under dynastic, Kshatrapa and local pressures with institutional continuity.

Answer: D - Regional fragmentation under dynastic, Kshatrapa and local pressures with institutional continuity.

Explanation: Multiple causes and regional successors are safer than a monocausal fall.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 17

Question: Which crop-process is a high-yield Deccan marker?

- A. Paddy transplantation in suitable Krishna-Godavari zones.
- B. Tea plantations.
- C. New World maize.
- D. Plantation rubber.

Answer: A - Paddy transplantation in suitable Krishna-Godavari zones.

Explanation: Wet-rice intensification supported selected eastern agrarian regions.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 18

Question: Which evidence best supports Deccan metalworking?

- A. Only royal genealogies.
- B. Iron artefacts, slag, forges and a blacksmith workshop at sites such as Peddabankur.
- C. Only the Gatha Sattasai.
- D. Only Pliny's army figures.

Answer: B - Iron artefacts, slag, forges and a blacksmith workshop at sites such as Peddabankur.

Explanation: Archaeology directly records production technology.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 19

Question: What is the key caution about Satavahana land grants?

- A. They did not involve land.
- B. They begin only after the Guptas.
- C. Early grants and immunities should not be equated automatically with mature feudalism.
- D. They were all made to Roman traders.

Answer: C - Early grants and immunities should not be equated automatically with mature feudalism.

Explanation: The records are early and important, but scale and standardization grew later.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 20

Question: Which donor must be distinguished as Kshatrapa rather than Satavahana?

- A. Gautami Balashri.
- B. Yajna Sri Satakarni.
- C. Naganika.
- D. Ushavadata.

Answer: D - Ushavadata.

Explanation: Ushavadata, Nahapana's son-in-law, made major Nashik and Karla donations.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 21

Question: Akshaya-nivi refers to:

- A. A perpetual endowment preserving the principal.
- B. A matronymic.
- C. A ship-type coin.
- D. A military camp.

Answer: A - A perpetual endowment preserving the principal.

Explanation: The term is important for institutional finance and durable pious endowments.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 22

Question: Why are guild endowments historically important?

- A. They prove monasteries minted all coins.
- B. They show corporate bodies acting as trusted managers of recurring funds.
- C. They abolished royal taxation.
- D. They were only hereditary priesthoods.

Answer: B - They show corporate bodies acting as trusted managers of recurring funds.

Explanation: Nashik-Junnar records connect economic corporations and religious support.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 23

Question: Which site yielded thousands of Satavahana coins and possible mint evidence?

- A. Sarnath.
- B. Uttaramerur.
- C. Peddabankur.
- D. Barabar.

Answer: C - Peddabankur.

Explanation: Peddabankur also had wells and a blacksmith workshop.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 24

Question: Bhokardan is especially useful for studying:

- A. Only Gupta temples.
- B. Only Vedic sacrifice.
- C. Only Harappan drainage.
- D. A route-town with bead, shell, ivory and metal crafts.

Answer: D - A route-town with bead, shell, ivory and metal crafts.

Explanation: Its craft debris and route position illuminate urban production.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 25

Question: Which inland towns are named by the Periplus in the western Deccan network?

- A. Paithana and Tagara.
- B. Nalanda and Rajagriha.
- C. Taxila and Purushapura.
- D. Puhar and Korkai only.

Answer: A - Paithana and Tagara.

Explanation: Paithan and Ter were connected to western maritime outlets.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 26

Question: The safest claim about Roman coins in the Deccan is:

- A. They prove universal Roman legal tender.
- B. They demonstrate contact and could function as coin, bullion, hoard or imported object depending on context.
- C. They show Roman colonies ruled the interior.
- D. They date every site to the issuing emperor's reign.

Answer: B - They demonstrate contact and could function as coin, bullion, hoard or imported object depending on context.

Explanation: Context determines use; arrival could be later than minting.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 27

Question: Which statement best bounds Indo-Roman trade?

- A. It ended all barter.
- B. It was a direct two-state treaty system.
- C. It was one strand within wider internal, Arabian Sea, Red Sea and Indian Ocean exchange.
- D. It replaced agriculture.

Answer: C - It was one strand within wider internal, Arabian Sea, Red Sea and Indian Ocean exchange.

Explanation: Multiple intermediaries and internal production must remain visible.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 28

Question: Satavahana lead coinage is significant because it:

- A. Was the only coinage in India.
- B. Was imported from Rome.
- C. Proves technological inferiority.
- D. Reflects regional monetary practice and Deccan mineral availability.

Answer: D - Reflects regional monetary practice and Deccan mineral availability.

Explanation: Metal choice must be interpreted regionally, not ranked as simple progress.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 29

Question: Which reading of coin distribution is methodologically correct?

- A. It must be cross-checked with mint, hoard, stratigraphy, inscriptions and trade movement.
- B. It measures population.
- C. It directly draws political borders.
- D. It proves personal royal religion.

Answer: A - It must be cross-checked with mint, hoard, stratigraphy, inscriptions and trade movement.

Explanation: Coins circulate beyond political control and can be redeposited.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 30

Question: Matronymics such as Gautamiputra indicate:

- A. Absence of royal marriage.
- B. Maternal lineage or gotra significance within a basically patrilineal dynasty.
- C. A proven matriarchal constitution.
- D. Election by Buddhist nuns.

Answer: B - Maternal lineage or gotra significance within a basically patrilineal dynasty.

Explanation: Royal women's authority and matronymics do not equal female-line succession.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 31

Question: Which royal woman is linked to Gautamiputra's Nashik eulogy?

- A. Naganika.
- B. Prabhavati Gupta.
- C. Gautami Balashri.
- D. Sanghamitta.

Answer: C - Gautami Balashri.

Explanation: Gautami Balashri fashioned the posthumous memory of her son.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 32

Question: Donor inscriptions of merchants and artisans most directly show:

- A. Complete equality in society.
- B. The disappearance of agriculture.
- C. A census of all workers.
- D. Public religious participation, surplus and occupational identity among visible donors.

Answer: D - Public religious participation, surplus and occupational identity among visible donors.

Explanation: The record is valuable but biased toward resource-holding donors.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 33

Question: The term *gandhika* is associated with:

- A. Perfumers or a wider shopkeeper identity in later usage.
- B. Royal mothers.
- C. Village headmen.
- D. Military camps.

Answer: A - Perfumers or a wider shopkeeper identity in later usage.

Explanation: Perfumers repeatedly appear among donors in the early historic record.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 34

Question: Which formulation best describes Satavahana religion?

- A. No institutional patronage.
- B. Brahmanical royal legitimation coexisted with Buddhist patronage and diverse donors.
- C. Exclusive rejection of Vedic rites.
- D. Exclusive state Buddhism.

Answer: B - Brahmanical royal legitimation coexisted with Buddhist patronage and diverse donors.

Explanation: Naneghat sacrifices and Nashik Buddhist grants must be held together.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 35

Question: What does a Buddhist donation by a ruler prove?

- A. Abolition of Brahmanical ritual.
- B. Monastic control of the state.
- C. Patronage and institutional support, not necessarily exclusive private conversion.
- D. The population's only religion.

Answer: C - Patronage and institutional support, not necessarily exclusive private conversion.

Explanation: Patronage could serve merit, legitimacy, alliances and route society.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 36

Question: Which language-script pairing is correct for Satavahana inscriptions?

- A. Tamil in Greek script.
- B. Sanskrit in Kharoshthi only.
- C. Pali in cuneiform.
- D. Prakrit in Brahmi.

Answer: D - Prakrit in Brahmi.

Explanation: Prakrit-Brahmi is the standard epigraphic association.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 37

Question: The Gatha Sattasai is:

- A. A Prakrit anthology attributed to Hala but subject to later compilation and retouching.
- B. Rudradaman's inscription.
- C. Gautamiputra's tax code.
- D. A contemporary Greek chronicle.

Answer: A - A Prakrit anthology attributed to Hala but subject to later compilation and retouching.

Explanation: Attribution and final textual form must be separated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 38

Question: Which statement distinguishes Karla correctly?

- A. It contains the Hathigumpha inscription.
- B. It is a major chaitya with diverse merchant, Yavana and elite patronage.
- C. It is only a Satavahana palace.
- D. It is an Ikshvaku brick temple.

Answer: B - It is a major chaitya with diverse merchant, Yavana and elite patronage.

Explanation: Karla is a multi-donor Buddhist cave complex on a western route.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 39

Question: Nashik caves are especially valuable because they preserve:

- A. Only Gupta copper plates.
- B. Only Mauryan edicts.
- C. Kshatrapa and Satavahana inscriptions, grants and monastic architecture.
- D. Only Sangam poetry.

Answer: C - Kshatrapa and Satavahana inscriptions, grants and monastic architecture.

Explanation: Rival political phases and donor records share the same landscape.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 40

Question: A chaitya is best defined as:

- A. A royal coin mint.
- B. A monastic cell block only.
- C. A village tax unit.
- D. A congregational worship hall, usually with a stupa in Buddhist cave contexts.

Answer: D - A congregational worship hall, usually with a stupa in Buddhist cave contexts.

Explanation: Chaitya and vihara must not be confused.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 41

Question: Which statement on Amaravati is correct?

- A. It was a lower Krishna mahachaitya with a long, multi-phase history.
- B. It had no urban context.
- C. It was founded only in the Ikshvaku period.
- D. It stood in Gandhara.

Answer: A - It was a lower Krishna mahachaitya with a long, multi-phase history.

Explanation: Its sequence begins early and crosses dynastic boundaries.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 42

Question: Ayaka pillars are associated especially with:

- A. All Gandharan monasteries.
- B. Some Andhra stupa traditions at the cardinal points.
- C. Every Satavahana coin.
- D. Mauryan court halls.

Answer: B - Some Andhra stupa traditions at the cardinal points.

Explanation: They are important but not universal even within Andhra.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 43

Question: What is the safest description of Amaravati influence?

- A. Satavahanas conquered Southeast Asia.
- B. Sri Lankan art was an exact copy.
- C. Artistic and Buddhist forms circulated toward Sri Lanka and wider maritime Asia.
- D. Only Roman artists produced the reliefs.

Answer: C - Artistic and Buddhist forms circulated toward Sri Lanka and wider maritime Asia.

Explanation: Cultural movement does not imply political rule or passive imitation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 44

Question: Why must Nagarjunakonda be bounded in this topic?

- A. It has no Buddhist remains.
- B. It predates all Satavahanas by millennia.
- C. It lies in the western Deccan.
- D. Its greatest monumental phase belongs mainly to Ikshvaku successor patronage.

Answer: D - Its greatest monumental phase belongs mainly to Ikshvaku successor patronage.

Explanation: It belongs to the broader Andhra landscape but is not simply a Satavahana site.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 45

Question: Which answer best explains Satavahana connective significance?

- A. They linked plateau agriculture, inland towns, western/eastern coasts and north-south cultural routes.
- B. They isolated the Deccan.
- C. They depended on one port.
- D. They abolished local elites.

Answer: A - They linked plateau agriculture, inland towns, western/eastern coasts and north-south cultural routes.

Explanation: Connectivity is the dynasty's core historical contribution.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 46

Question: Which source is least suitable as a literal administrative census?

- A. A labelled royal inscription.
- B. Pliny's statement about Andhra towns and army numbers.
- C. A dated land-grant inscription.
- D. A stratified mint context.

Answer: B - Pliny's statement about Andhra towns and army numbers.

Explanation: External numerical claims require genre and transmission caution.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 47

Question: What is the best 20-mark thesis?

- A. The dynasty mattered only for one victory over Nahapana.
- B. Roman trade fully explains its rise and fall.
- C. Satavahana power was a layered Deccan network joining agrarian, commercial and religious nodes, with uneven territorial control.
- D. Matronymics prove a matriarchal empire.

Answer: C - Satavahana power was a layered Deccan network joining agrarian, commercial and religious nodes, with uneven territorial control.

Explanation: The thesis accommodates polity, economy, society, culture and source limits.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Hard MCQ 48

Question: What should a source-critical conclusion emphasize?

- A. Coin finds replace all inscriptions.
- B. One source must always be accepted literally.
- C. Debate makes history impossible.
- D. Convergence among inscriptions, coins, archaeology and texts, while preserving their different limits.

Answer: D - Convergence among inscriptions, coins, archaeology and texts, while preserving their different limits.

Explanation: Triangulation produces graded confidence rather than certainty or skepticism.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 49

Question: Remedial: Satavahana chronology should be written as:

- A. Broad phases with source-specific dates and explicit debate.
- B. Only a Puranic total.
- C. One universally fixed genealogy.
- D. Only the reign of Gautamiputra.

Answer: A - Broad phases with source-specific dates and explicit debate.

Explanation: Chronology is reconstructed and must remain qualified.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 50

Question: Remedial: 'Andhra' in the Puranas means:

- A. A Roman province.
- B. A dynastic/regional identification requiring interpretation, not automatic proof of one origin.
- C. A fixed capital name.
- D. A Buddhist sect.

Answer: B - A dynastic/regional identification requiring interpretation, not automatic proof of one origin.

Explanation: Puranic and epigraphic naming do not align perfectly.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 51

Question: Remedial: Gautamiputra's varna claim is:

- A. A population census.
- B. An archaeological layer.
- C. A royal ideological statement.
- D. A guild contract.

Answer: C - A royal ideological statement.

Explanation: Prashasti rhetoric is evidence for kingship ideals.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 52

Question: Remedial: Matronymic does not mean:

- A. Maternal association.
- B. Gotra relevance.
- C. Parentage identification.
- D. Matriarchy.

Answer: D - Matriarchy.

Explanation: Succession remained substantially patrilineal.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 53

Question: Remedial: Ushavadata was:

- A. Nahapana's son-in-law and a Kshatrapa donor.
- B. A Roman merchant.
- C. A Satavahana founder.
- D. An Ikshvaku king.

Answer: A - Nahapana's son-in-law and a Kshatrapa donor.

Explanation: Correct patron identification prevents mixing rival archives.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 54

Question: Remedial: Nahapana overstrikes prove most securely:

- A. The end of barter.
- B. Gautamiputra's political victory and currency reuse in a regional context.
- C. Permanent control of all western India.
- D. Universal silver coinage.

Answer: B - Gautamiputra's political victory and currency reuse in a regional context.

Explanation: The evidence is strong but bounded.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 55

Question: Remedial: Satavahana prosperity was based on:

- A. Land grants alone.
- B. Roman trade alone.
- C. Agriculture, crafts, internal routes and external exchange together.
- D. War booty alone.

Answer: C - Agriculture, crafts, internal routes and external exchange together.

Explanation: A multi-base economy avoids dependency narratives.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 56

Question: Remedial: Karla and Nashik show:

- A. No political competition.
- B. One exclusive royal religion.
- C. Absence of merchants.
- D. Multi-donor Buddhist institutions connected to route society.

Answer: D - Multi-donor Buddhist institutions connected to route society.

Explanation: Their inscriptions preserve rulers, chiefs, merchants and artisans.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 57

Question: Remedial: Amaravati should be dated as:

- A. A long multi-phase monument spanning more than one dynasty.
- B. Only Ikshvaku.
- C. Only Mauryan.
- D. One building campaign of Yajna Sri.

Answer: A - A long multi-phase monument spanning more than one dynasty.

Explanation: Its development cannot be compressed into one reign.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 58

Question: Remedial: Ship coins of Yajna Sri indicate:

- A. Roman suzerainty.
- B. Maritime orientation and symbolism.
- C. No inland economy.
- D. A documented overseas empire.

Answer: B - Maritime orientation and symbolism.

Explanation: Iconography must not be overextended.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 59

Question: Remedial: The best polity label is:

- A. Stateless tribal zone.
- B. Foreign colony.
- C. Layered or network polity with real but uneven royal power.
- D. Centralized empire with identical administration.

Answer: C - Layered or network polity with real but uneven royal power.

Explanation: The label integrates offices, chiefs, grants and routes.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

Remedial MCQ 60

Question: Remedial: Evidence in a Mains answer should follow:

- A. Name-list -> quotation -> conclusion.
- B. Opinion without source.
- C. Chronology only.
- D. Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limitation.

Answer: D - Claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limitation.

Explanation: The sequence converts factual recall into examiner-grade analysis.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option crosses a dynasty/source, erases a chronology caveat, centralizes too much or turns a qualified claim into an absolute.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2026 Prelims GS-I Q13: Amaravati Stupa

Status: Official Set-A question verified locally; answer from the locally held provisional 2026 key.

Question: Which statements on the Amaravati Stupa and its relief sculpture are correct? (1) It was located in the lower Krishna valley. (2) In India, it was next only to the Sanchi Stupa in size. (3) The Amaravati school made a lasting impact on later South Indian sculpture, and its products were carried to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C - 1 and 3 only (PROVISIONAL OFFICIAL KEY).

Model solution

- Statement 1 is correct: Amaravati-Dharanikota lies in the lower Krishna valley.
- Statement 2 is incorrect in the paper's framing. Amaravati was the great Andhra mahachaitya; the statement making it merely next to Sanchi is not accepted by the provisional key.
- Statement 3 is correct: the Andhra/Amaravati visual idiom influenced later southern production, and portable works or stylistic forms travelled to Sri Lanka and wider maritime networks.
- LIMIT: Artistic movement does not prove Satavahana political control over Sri Lanka or Southeast Asia.

Why this earns marks: It uses the provisional key transparently, tests each statement independently and adds the crucial art-circulation versus political-rule distinction.

PYQ 02 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q41: Dhanyakataka

Status: Official question verified locally; official answer key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED; high confidence.

Question: In which region was Dhanyakataka, which flourished as a prominent Buddhist centre under the Mahasanghikas, located?

- A. Andhra
- B. Gandhara
- C. Kalinga
- D. Magadha

Answer: A - Andhra (INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED).

Model solution

- Dhanyakataka/Dharanikota belongs to the lower Krishna-Andhra Buddhist landscape associated with Amaravati.
- Gandhara is north-western, Kalinga lies mainly in coastal Odisha, and Magadha belongs to the middle Gangetic region.
- LIMIT: The relationship between named sects, sites and later textual traditions must not be made more uniform than the evidence permits.

Why this earns marks: It solves through regional sacred geography and clearly labels the unavailable official key.

PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains Q1: rock-cut architecture

Status: Official printed Mains question verified from the locally held UPSC paper.

Question: The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Answer: Model answer

Model solution

- Direct thesis: Rock-cut monuments are durable archives because architecture, images and inscriptions preserve institutions, technology, routes and patronage that literary narratives often omit.
- Claim and evidence: Barabar caves donated by Ashoka and Dasharatha to Ajivikas show early royal patronage and polished-stone skill; they also warn against equating rock-cut architecture only with Buddhism.
- Claim and evidence: Bhaja, Karla and Nashik chaitya-viharas reveal congregational halls, monastic cells and changing scale. Karla's merchant and Yavana donors connect art with route society, while Nashik inscriptions of Ushavadata and Gautamiputra record rival rule, endowments and land rights.
- Claim and evidence: Ajanta's early chaityas and later paintings document long religious and artistic change, not one dynastic moment.
- Qualification: Caves privilege patrons and durable religious institutions; they must be phased carefully and checked against settlements, coins and texts.
- Conclusion: Rock-cut sites are therefore combined architectural, epigraphic and social archives rather than monuments of style alone.

Why this earns marks: It answers why caves are sources, uses four named evidence clusters, explains what each proves and closes with a methodological limitation.

PYQ 04 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q42: stupa origin and function

Status: Official question verified locally; official answer key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED; high confidence.

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

Answer: B - Only two (INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED).

Model solution

- Statement 1 is incorrect: funerary mound traditions pre-date or extend beyond Buddhism, although Buddhism transformed and greatly expanded the stupa.
- Statement 2 is correct as a general statement: many Buddhist stupas enshrined corporeal or associated relics, though not every stupa necessarily did so.
- Statement 3 is correct: Buddhist stupas also served votive and commemorative functions.

- Satavahana link: Amaravati was a mahachaitya with a long architectural and sculptural sequence; its history must not be reduced to a relic container alone.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates every statement independently, distinguishes origin from Buddhist development and applies the result to Amaravati without overgeneralizing.

Mains 10M-1 - Network polity

Question: Why is the Satavahana state better described as a layered or network polity than as a uniformly centralized empire? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana kings exercised substantial military and fiscal power, but their realm was integrated through graded authority rather than one uniform bureaucracy.
- Claim and evidence: Aharas, amatyas, mahamatras and gramikas show royal administration. Significance: the crown could divide territory, issue records and work through officials. Limit: shared vocabulary with Mauryas does not prove identical administrative depth.
- Claim and evidence: Maharathis and mahabhojas appear as cave donors, coin-issuing local elites and matrimonial partners. Significance: royal power enclosed existing lineages instead of eliminating them. Limit: their precise legal rank varied by place and time.
- Claim and evidence: Kura, Ananda and Sada families plus mobile kataka or skandhavara centres indicate differentiated control. Significance: sovereignty depended on local anchorage and movement.
- Conclusion: The Satavahana realm was therefore a powerful but uneven network connecting court, chiefs, villages, routes and religious institutions.

Why this earns marks: It supplies three named evidence units, explains what each proves, qualifies the centralization claim and gives a direct verdict suited to 10 marks.

Mains 10M-2 - Nahapana overstrikes

Question: Assess the historical value of Gautamiputra Satakarni's overstrikes on Nahapana's coins. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The overstrikes are unusually strong material evidence for political reversal, but they are not a complete territorial map.
- Claim and evidence: The Jogalthambi hoard near Nashik contained more than 8,000 Nahapana silver coins in RS Sharma's account, many restruck by Gautamiputra. Significance: the new ruler appropriated an existing currency stock while replacing Kshaharata authority.
- Claim and evidence: Gautamiputra's Nashik inscriptions and Gautami Balashri's prashasti call him exterminator of the Kshaharatas. Significance: numismatics independently supports the dynastic victory claim.
- Claim and evidence: A Gautamiputra grant concerns land formerly under Ushavadata's jurisdiction. Significance: conquest altered fiscal and institutional control, not only coin imagery.
- Qualification: Overstriking may also reflect metal economy and currency continuity; it cannot establish the duration or exact frontier of restored rule.
- Conclusion: Read together, coin, inscription and grant form a high-confidence but regionally bounded reconstruction.

Why this earns marks: It triangulates coin, prashasti and grant evidence and explicitly separates strong event proof from weak border inference.

Mains 10M-3 - Matronymics and women

Question: What do Satavahana matronymics and inscriptions reveal about royal women? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana evidence gives royal women unusual genealogical and donor visibility, but it does not establish matriarchy.
- Claim and evidence: Names such as Gautamiputra and Vasisthiputra associate kings with the mother's gotra or parentage. Significance: maternal lineage mattered in a polygynous and alliance-based court. Limit: kings still succeeded through a male dynastic line.
- Claim and evidence: Naganika's Naneghat inscription records genealogy, sacrifices and lavish dakshina. Significance: a queen could shape ritual legitimacy and public royal memory.
- Claim and evidence: Gautami Balashri's Nashik inscription eulogizes her deceased son. Significance: the king's mother became an authoritative dynastic voice.
- Claim and evidence: Women donors and the Nashik woman doorkeeper Lota widen the archive beyond queens. Limit: inscription-making privileges resource-holding women.
- Conclusion: The evidence reveals significant female agency within, not outside, a patriarchal political order.

Why this earns marks: It answers both matronymics and inscriptional agency, uses more than three precise examples and avoids the matriarchy trap.

Mains 15M-1 - Chronology, genealogy and political geography

Question: Discuss the principal problems in reconstructing Satavahana chronology, genealogy and political geography. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana sequence is recoverable in broad phases, but exact dates, origins, capitals and borders remain debated because the archives are discontinuous and differently motivated.
- Puranic problem: Matsya and Brahmanda traditions list about 30 kings and long duration, while Vayu and shorter reconstructions differ. Significance: they preserve dynastic memory. Limit: recension, total years and Andhra-bhritya interpretation are contested.
- Epigraphic anchor: Naneghat labels Simuka, Naganika, Satakarni and princes; Nashik records anchor Gautamiputra and Pulumavi. Significance: contemporary names and relationships. Limit: damage and prashasti form prevent a complete genealogy.
- Numismatic anchor: early coins at Kotalingala and Sangareddy support an eastern-origin hypothesis; Naneghat-Nashik inscriptions support western beginnings; later coin-only rulers are absent from Puranic lists. Significance: coins fill textual gaps. Limit: circulation is not identical to political core.
- Political-geography control: Gautami Balashri lists many lands, Gautamiputra restrikes Nahapana, and Rudradaman's Junagadh prashasti claims western victories. Together they show wide but shifting power. Limit: universal claims and rival eulogies cannot be literalized.
- Capital problem: Pratishthana was a major western centre; Dharanikota-Dhanyakataka became important in the eastern phase. A single permanent-capital model is unsafe.
- Conclusion: The most credible reconstruction uses broad ranges and a moving map built from convergent evidence, not one harmonized king-list.

Why this earns marks: It uses five evidence clusters across every part of the demand, distinguishes source strengths and gives a methodologically reasoned verdict.

Mains 15M-2 - Agrarian economy, grants and urban growth

Question: Analyse the relationship among agrarian expansion, land grants, crafts and towns in the Satavahana Deccan. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana urban and political growth rested on interaction between productive rural zones, transferable fiscal rights, specialized crafts and route-linked towns.
- Agrarian claim and evidence: socketed hoes, ploughshares, sickles and iron-working at Peddabankur and other sites support intensified cultivation. Paddy transplantation and the Krishna-Godavari rice zone increased surplus, while cotton fed textile production. Limit: tools and crop references do not quantify output across the entire plateau.
- Settlement claim and evidence: Peddabankur's wells, drains, possible mint and blacksmith workshop; Dhulikatta's fortification; Bhokardan's bead, shell, ivory and metal debris reveal differentiated towns. Significance: towns concentrated production, exchange and administration.
- Grant claim and evidence: Naganika's Naneghat record includes villages in dakshina; Gautamiputra's Nashik field grant exempted monks from royal entry, salt digging and district interference. Significance: the state transferred revenue and jurisdictional rights. Limit: this is an early template, not proof of mature feudalism.
- Guild claim and evidence: Ushavadata's investment with Govardhana weavers and Junnar corporate donations show guilds managing recurring resources for monasteries. Though Kshatrapa evidence, it belongs to the same western Deccan institutional field.
- Conclusion: Agriculture supplied the base, crafts and routes generated nodal towns, and grants reorganized surplus and authority; none of these mechanisms worked in isolation.

Why this earns marks: It integrates five named evidence units into one causal chain and explicitly distinguishes Kshatrapa evidence and later-feudal overstatement.

Mains 15M-3 - Plural patronage

Question: How did Brahmanical legitimation and Buddhist patronage coexist under the Satavahanas? (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Brahmanical kingship and Buddhist patronage were complementary strategies operating through different institutions, audiences and forms of merit.
- Brahmanical claim and evidence: Naganika's Naneghat inscription invokes deities and records rajasuya, two ashvamedhas and lavish dakshina. Significance: shrauta ritual established royal sovereignty and alliance with Brahmanas. Limit: it describes elite ideology, not exclusive social religion.
- Royal ideology claim and evidence: Gautami Balashri calls Gautamiputra a peerless Brahmana and restorer of varna order. Significance: Brahmanical identity answered political competition. Limit: the eulogy cannot be treated as a demographic fact.
- Buddhist claim and evidence: Gautamiputra granted a Nashik field to monks with fiscal immunities; western caves preserve Satavahana, Kshatrapa, merchant and artisan gifts. Significance: rulers and social groups supported durable route-side institutions.
- Donor-network claim and evidence: Karla's merchants and Yavanas, Junnar guilds and Nashik endowments show that Buddhist establishments drew support beyond the court. Significance: monasteries became nodes of merit, identity and social trust. Limit: patronage does not prove conversion.
- Art claim and evidence: Amaravati's mahachaitya and western chaitya-viharas materialized cumulative patronage across phases. Limit: not every monument or later Andhra development was Satavahana.
- Conclusion: Satavahana plural patronage joined Brahmanical royal legitimacy to socially broad Buddhist institutions without creating a single state religion.

Why this earns marks: It uses six evidence units, differentiates ideology from patronage and includes donor, regional and chronological limits.

Mains 20M-1 - Deccan bridge

Question: The Satavahanas connected north and south, coast and interior, agrarian production and long-distance exchange. Critically examine. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana significance was connective, but the connections formed a regionally uneven network rather than a uniformly controlled commercial empire.
- Geography and evidence: Naneghat linked the Konkan coast to the plateau, while the Godavari route joined Pratishthana, Tagara and eastern zones. Significance: passes and river valleys translated terrain into political and commercial nodes. Limit: routes changed hands during Kshatrapa conflict.
- Agrarian base and evidence: iron tools, paddy transplantation in Krishna-Godavari zones and cotton production supported surplus and textile exchange. Significance: connectivity rested on hinterland production, not foreign trade alone.
- Urban-craft evidence: Peddabankur's mint, wells and forge; Bhokardan's bead and ivory industries; Adam's coins and moulds show productive inland towns. Limit: excavated centres cannot represent every locality.
- Coastal and overseas evidence: the Periplus names Paithana and Tagara; Roman coins, amphorae and Amaravati's wharf show Indian Ocean-linked contact. Significance: Deccan goods and bullion entered wider circuits. Limit: imports do not prove economic dependence or Roman settlement.
- Political evidence: Gautamiputra's Nahapana overstrikes and Nashik grants show that control of western access had military and fiscal consequences. Rudradaman's recovery proves unstable frontiers.
- Cultural evidence: Prakrit-Brahmi inscriptions, western caves and Amaravati art connected local patrons to wider Buddhist and Brahmanical worlds. Limit: circulation did not mean political conquest of Sri Lanka or Southeast Asia.
- Conclusion: The Satavahanas' achievement was to stabilize and exploit a Deccan web of production, authority and movement; its very nodal character explains both reach and uneven control.

Why this earns marks: It uses more than seven named evidence units across every pair in the question, sustains the critical qualification and ends with a network-based verdict.

Mains 20M-2 - Centralization debate

Question: Critically examine the view that the Satavahanas created a centralized empire in the Deccan. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Satavahanas created durable paramountcy and administrative capacity, but centralized-empire language exaggerates territorial uniformity.
- Case for state capacity: aharas, amatyas, mahamatras, mahasenapatis, gramikas, scribes and record keepers demonstrate administrative divisions and documentary government. Kataka and skandhavera show mobile coercive centres. Gautamiputra's grant immunities presuppose officials whose entry could be prohibited.
- Case for military-fiscal reach: the Nahapana overstrikes, recovery of Nashik-Pune areas and wide regional claims in Gautami Balashri's prashasti show that the crown could conquer, redistribute land and communicate sovereignty.
- Counter-evidence from local elites: maharathis and mahabhojas retained donor, matrimonial and probably territorial importance. Kura, Ananda, Sada and other coin-issuing families reveal regional bases not erased by kingship.
- Counter-evidence from political geography: western ports and Malwa changed hands between Satavahanas and Kshatrapas; Pulumavi's eastern strength coexisted with Rudradaman's western recovery. Prashasti horses drinking three oceans are ideology, not an administrative survey.
- Institutional network: Brahmanas, Buddhist monasteries, guilds and merchants received resources and mediated legitimacy. This widened royal influence while dispersing rights and authority.
- Historiographical verdict: B. D. Chattopadhyaya's locality approach and Upinder Singh's evidence support encapsulation of pre-existing elites. Yet network polity must not be confused with weakness: the crown remained the premier war-making and grant-making power.

- Conclusion: The Satavahana state was neither Mauryan centralization nor loose chieftdom; it was a layered Deccan polity with strong nodes and uneven direct rule.

Why this earns marks: It presents both state capacity and counter-evidence, uses administrative, numismatic, inscriptional and local-lineage proof, and gives a graded rather than binary verdict.

Mains 20M-3 - Source criticism

Question: How do inscriptions, coins and archaeology together reconstruct Satavahana history, and where do they leave uncertainty? (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Satavahana history is strongest where independent source classes converge and weakest where historians force one source to answer questions outside its capacity.
- Inscriptions: Naneghat supplies Simuka-Satakarni-Naganika genealogy, sacrifices and route-side kingship; Nashik supplies Gautamiputra's eulogy, grants and rival Kshatrapa layers. Significance: names, titles and institutions are contemporary. Limit: damage, formula and prashasti exaggeration.
- Coins: Kotalingala and Sangareddy finds enter the origin debate; Jogalthambi overstrikes corroborate Nahapana's defeat; Pulumavi's eastern and Yajna Sri's wide issues map phases; later coin-only rulers fill king-list gaps. Limit: circulation, hoarding and later movement prevent automatic border drawing.
- Archaeology: Peddabankur, Dhulikatta, Bhokardan, Adam and Dharanikota-Amaravati reveal towns, mints, crafts, drains, fortifications, channels and monasteries. Significance: material life and non-royal actors become visible. Limit: dating, site coverage and ruler attribution remain uneven.
- Texts as controls: Puranas preserve conflicting king-lists; the Periplus identifies routes and markets; Pliny offers Andhra town and army claims. Significance: they widen chronology and economy. Limit: recension, genre and outsider perspective.
- Convergence example: Gautamiputra's victory rests on Nashik claims, overstruck coins and land formerly tied to Ushavadata. This is high-confidence regional history.
- Residual uncertainty: original homeland, absolute chronology, capital sequence, exact frontiers, demographic varna practice and causes of decline remain debated.
- Conclusion: Triangulation yields graded confidence, not a single seamless narrative; uncertainty is a feature of disciplined history, not a defect to be hidden.

Why this earns marks: It is organized by source class, attaches significance and limit to every named item, demonstrates convergence and explicitly identifies unresolved questions.